Ten Boats Home

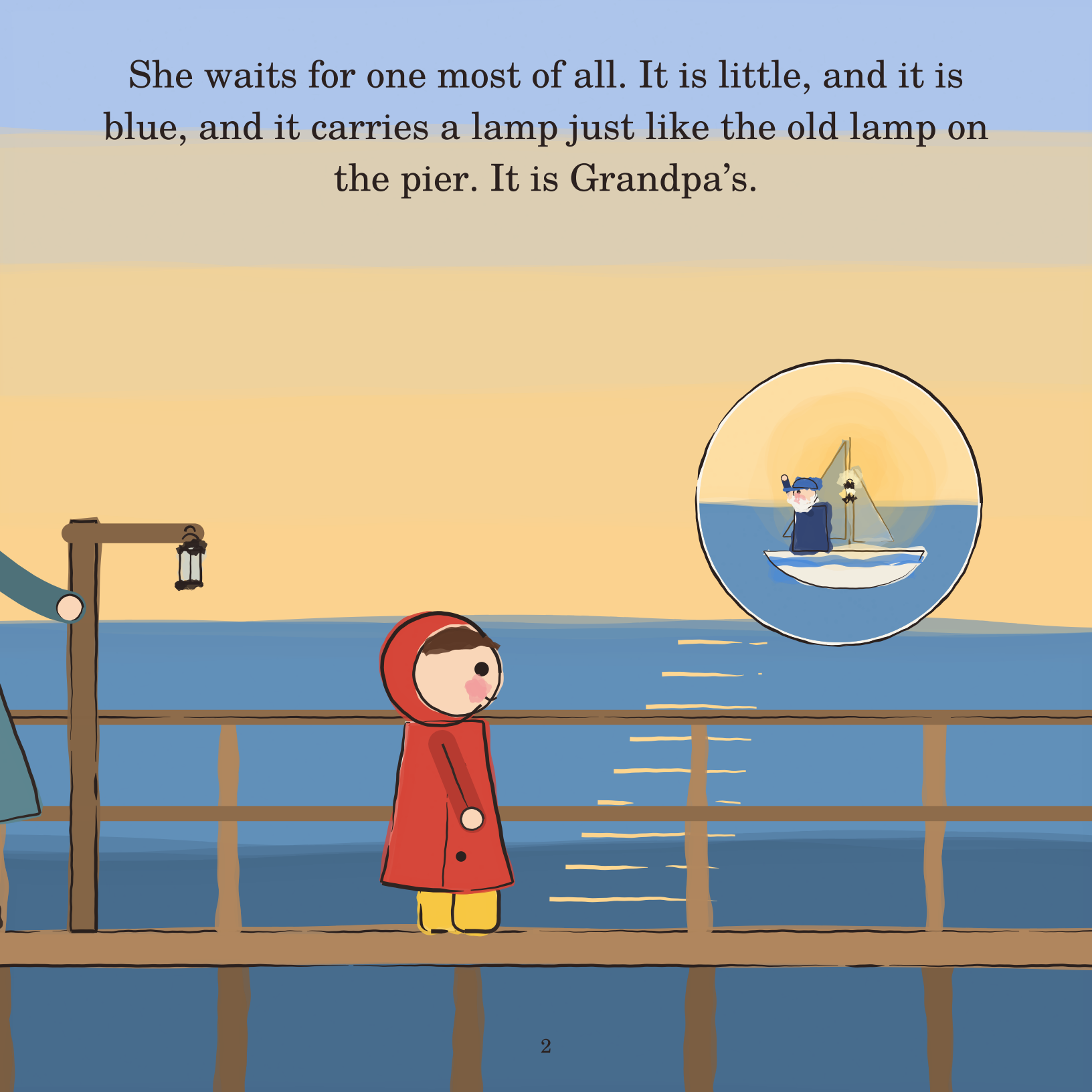
a counting book



Ten boats sail out in the morning. Every evening, Ana counts them home, while Mama mends the nets.



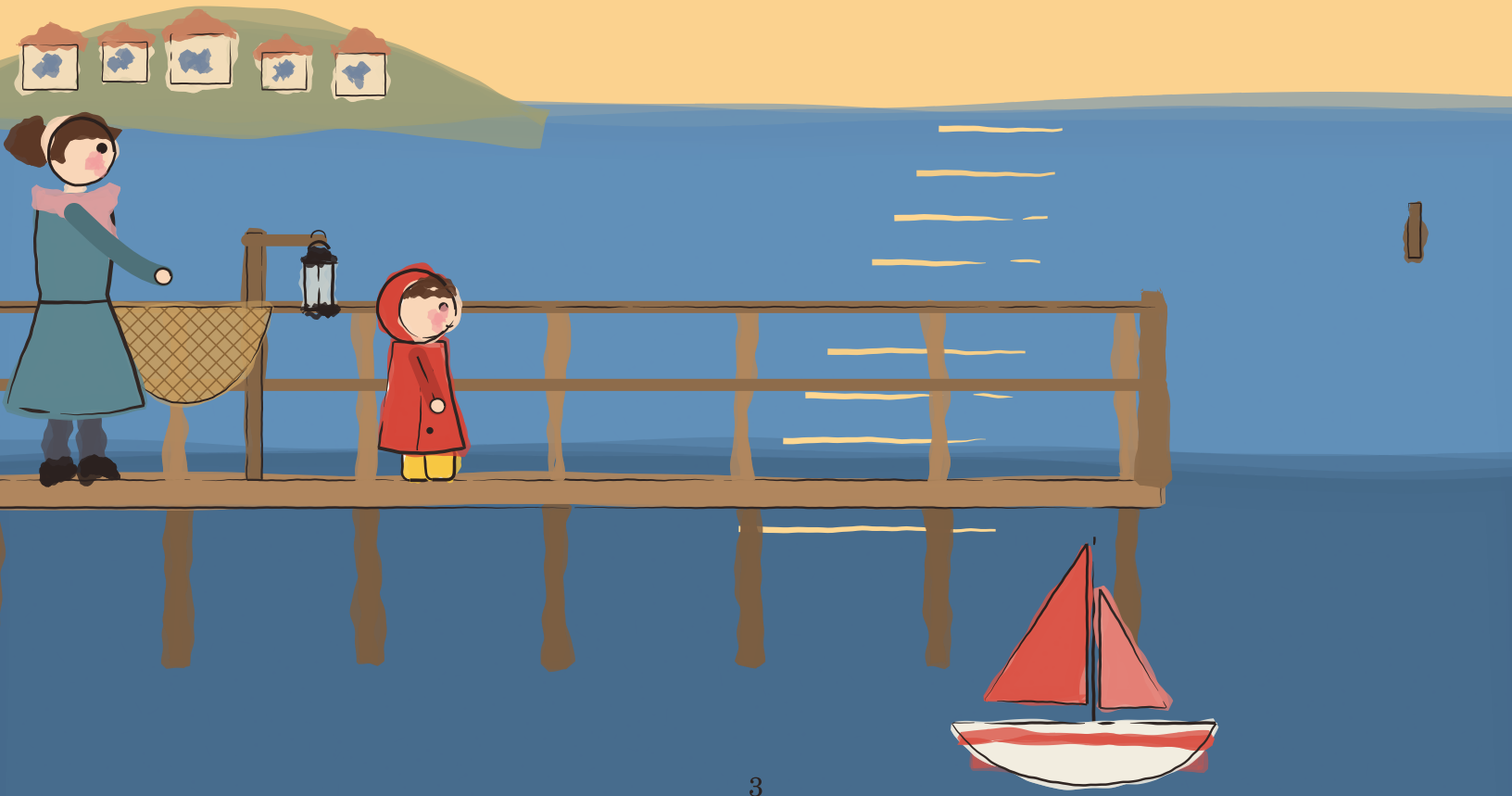
She waits for one most of all. It is little, and it is blue, and it carries a lamp just like the old lamp on the pier. It is Grandpa's.



Red sail.

One!

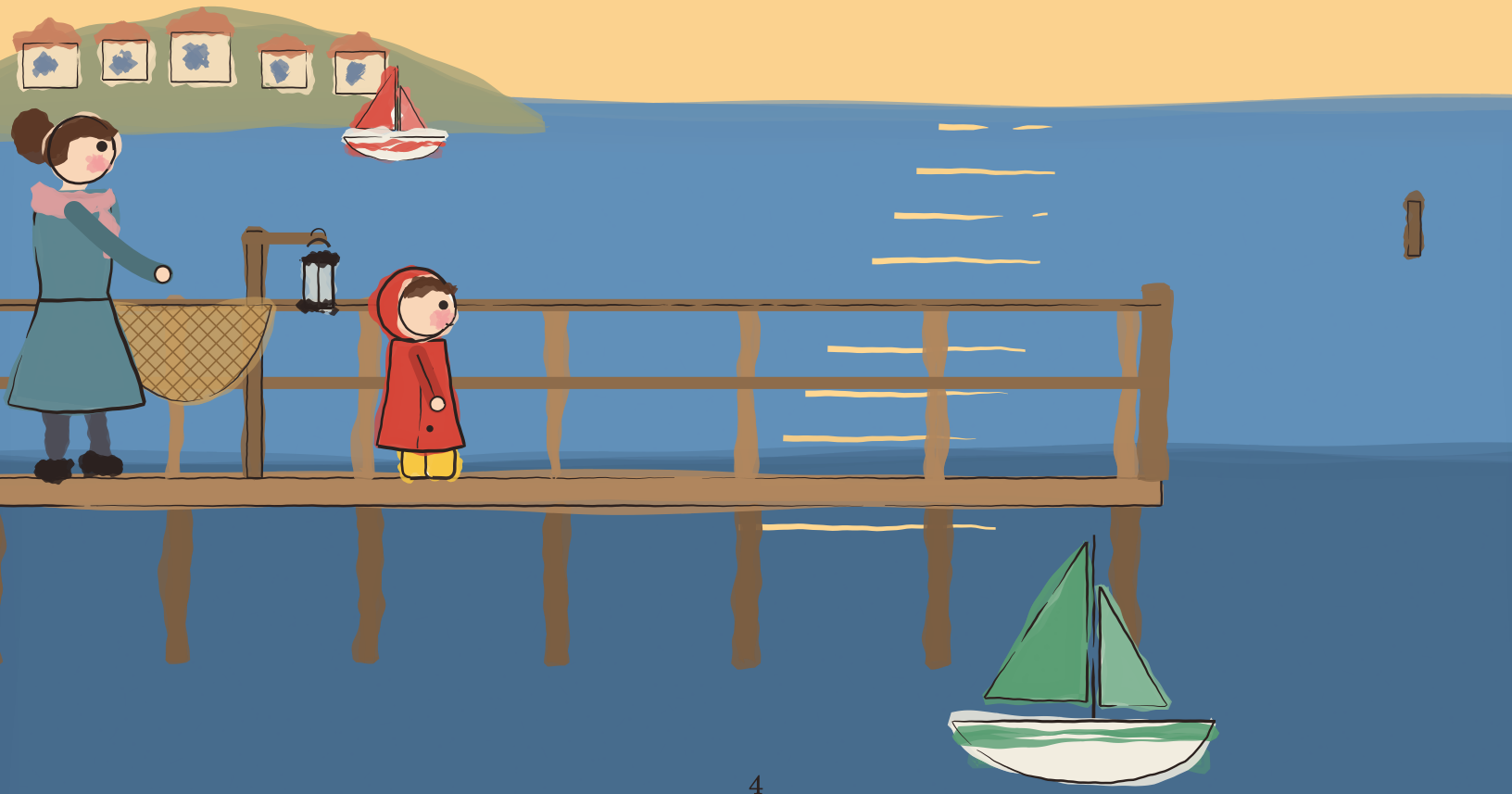
Not Grandpa's.



Green sail.

Two!

Not Grandpa's.



Three! Four! Five!

Not one of them is Grandpa's.



Six. Seven. Eight. … Nine.

Not little. Not blue. Not Grandpa's.



The gulls go quiet. Ana waits for ten.



But ten is not a boat.

Ten is fog.



The fog swallows the boats. It swallows the pier.
“Where is Grandpa?” Ana whispers.



Then Ana thinks of Grandpa's lamp. She lifts the old lamp from its hook. "Mama! Light it, quick!"



Mama lights it. Click goes the little glass door. And out they go, into the fog.



At the very end, Ana holds the lamp up high.
Nothing. Only fog.



So she holds it higher.



Out in the fog, something blinks back. A little light. A little boat. A little blue boat.



Ten!

Ten boats home. And this one is Grandpa's.



He lifts Ana up, lamp and all. “Ten boats home,” says Grandpa, “and one little light.”



“Eleven,”

says Ana.



